

1. The Five Tones

— every syllable has a pitch; get the pitch wrong and the meaning changes

| Tone          | Sample | Pitch shape | Meaning                                     |                     |
|---------------|--------|-------------|---------------------------------------------|---------------------|
| 1st — flat    | 妈      | mā          | high and level (like singing a steady note) | mum                 |
| 2nd — rising  | 麻      | má          | rises, like a question "Huh?"               | hemp                |
| 3rd — dipping | 马      | mǎ          | starts low, dips, then rises again          | horse               |
| 4th — falling | 骂      | mà          | sharp, forceful fall (like "No!")           | scold               |
| neutral       | 吗      | ma          | short, light, unstressed                    | (question particle) |

2. Tone-Pair Drills

— words are built from pairs; drill every combination (O = neutral)

|                                                    |                                                    |                                                                                                      |                                                   |                                                                      |
|----------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <div>1 + 1</div> <div>fēijī</div> <div>飞机</div>    | <div>1 + 2</div> <div>Zhōngguó</div> <div>中国</div> | <div>1 + 3</div> <div>jīchǎng</div> <div>机场</div>                                                    | <div>1 + 4</div> <div>yīyuàn</div> <div>医院</div>  | <div>1 + 0</div> <div>māma</div> <div>妈妈</div> <div>neutral</div>    |
| <div>2 + 1</div> <div>fángjiān</div> <div>房间</div> | <div>2 + 2</div> <div>xuéxí</div> <div>学习</div>    | <div>2 + 3</div> <div>niúnnǎi</div> <div>牛奶</div>                                                    | <div>2 + 4</div> <div>xuéxiào</div> <div>学校</div> | <div>2 + 0</div> <div>péngyou</div> <div>朋友</div> <div>neutral</div> |
| <div>3 + 1</div> <div>lǎoshī</div> <div>老师</div>   | <div>3 + 2</div> <div>kěnéng</div> <div>可能</div>   | <div>3 + 3</div> <div>shuǐguǒ</div> <div>水果</div> <div>reads ní / shuǐ-guo — first becomes 2nd</div> | <div>3 + 4</div> <div>kǎoshì</div> <div>考试</div>  | <div>3 + 0</div> <div>jiějie</div> <div>姐姐</div> <div>neutral</div>  |
| <div>4 + 1</div> <div>dàiyī</div> <div>大衣</div>    | <div>4 + 2</div> <div>qùnián</div> <div>去年</div>   | <div>4 + 3</div> <div>Hànyǔ</div> <div>汉语</div>                                                      | <div>4 + 4</div> <div>zàijiàn</div> <div>再见</div> | <div>4 + 0</div> <div>bàba</div> <div>爸爸</div> <div>neutral</div>    |

3rd-tone rule: 3rd + 3rd → the FIRST 3rd tone is read as a 2nd tone: 你好 nǐ hǎo → ní hǎo; 水果 shuǐguǒ → shuǐguǒ.

一 / 不 rules: 一 is 2nd tone before a 4th tone (一个 yí ge, 一次 yí cì) and 4th tone before 1st/2nd/3rd (一天 yì tiān, 一起 yì qǐ). 不 is 2nd tone before a 4th tone (不是 bú shì, 不对 bú duì) and 4th tone elsewhere (不好 bù hǎo).

3. Contrast Pairs

— same sound, different tone, different word

| syllable | 1st tone   | 2nd tone       | 3rd tone   | 4th tone         |
|----------|------------|----------------|------------|------------------|
| ma       | 妈<br>mum   | 麻<br>hemp/flax | 马<br>horse | 骂<br>scold       |
| yi       | 一<br>one   | 姨<br>aunt      | 椅<br>chair | 亿<br>100 million |
| ba       | 八<br>eight | 拔<br>pull      | 把<br>grasp | 爸<br>dad         |

|       |                |               |                |               |
|-------|----------------|---------------|----------------|---------------|
| shi   | 诗<br>poem      | 时<br>time     | 屎<br>excrement | 是<br>to be    |
| xiang | 香<br>fragrant  | 祥<br>lucky    | 想<br>think     | 向<br>towards  |
| zhi   | 知<br>know      | 直<br>straight | 纸<br>paper     | 志<br>ambition |
| tong  | 通<br>through   | 同<br>same     | 统<br>unify     | 痛<br>pain     |
| tu    | 秃<br>bald      | 图<br>picture  | 土<br>earth     | 兔<br>rabbit   |
| wu    | 屋<br>house     | 无<br>without  | 五<br>five      | 雾<br>fog      |
| mai   | 埋<br>bury      | 买<br>buy      | 卖<br>sell      |               |
| da    | 答<br>answer    | 打<br>hit      | 大<br>big       |               |
| chou  | 抽<br>draw/take | 愁<br>worry    | 丑<br>ugly      | 臭<br>stinky   |

4. Tricky Near Pairs — say these aloud until they feel different

|                    |    |                        |            |
|--------------------|----|------------------------|------------|
| 买 mǎi (buy)        | vs | 卖 mài (sell)           | 把三本书卖了。    |
| 打 dǎ (hit)         | vs | 大 dà (big)             | 你别打我!      |
| 想 xiǎng (think)    | vs | 像 xiàng (like/as)      | 我想他像他爸爸。   |
| 水 shuǐ (water)     | vs | 睡 shuì (sleep)         | 我要喝水然后睡觉。  |
| 五 wǔ (five)        | vs | 无 wú (none)            | 星期五我去。     |
| 四 sì (four)        | vs | 十 shí (ten)            | 四和十， 很难分清。 |
| 衣服 yīfu (clothes)  | vs | 姨父 yífu (uncle)        | 姨父买了新衣服。   |
| 西 xī (west)        | vs | 洗 xǐ (wash)            | 他在西边洗衣服。   |
| 篮子 lánzi (basket)  | vs | 懒子 lǎnzi (lazybones)   | 懒汉拿篮子。     |
| 下雨 xiàyǔ (to rain) | vs | 夏雨 xiàyǔ (summer rain) | 夏雨大， 下雨了。  |

**Classic drill:** 妈妈骑马， 马慢， 妈妈骂马。(Māma qí mǎ, mǎ màn, māma mà mǎ.) — "Mom rides a horse; the horse is slow; Mom scolds the horse."

5. 60 Practice Sentences — read aloud, then listen to your own recording

|                                                                         |                                                                         |
|-------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1 你好!<br>Nǐ hǎo!<br>Hello!                                              | 2 你好吗?<br>Nǐ hǎo ma?<br>How are you?                                    |
| 3 我很高兴认识你。<br>Wǒ hěn gāoxìng rènshi nǐ.<br>I am very glad to meet you.  | 4 今天天气很好。<br>Jīntiān tiānqì hěn hǎo.<br>The weather is very nice today. |
| 5 我明天去北京。<br>Wǒ míngtiān qù Běijīng.<br>I am going to Beijing tomorrow. | 6 他是我朋友。<br>Tā shì wǒ péngyou.<br>He is my friend.                      |
| 7 妈妈在做饭。<br>Māma zài zuǒfàn.<br>Mom is cooking.                         | 8 我喜欢喝茶。<br>Wǒ xǐhuān hē chá.<br>I like drinking tea.                   |

9 请问，厕所在哪儿？

Qǐngwèn, cèsuǒ zài nǎr?

Excuse me, where is the restroom?

11 没关系。

Méi guānxi.

It's okay.

13 再见！

Zàijiàn!

Goodbye!

15 他每天跑步。

Tā měitiān pǎobù.

He runs every day.

17 现在几点了？

Xiànzài jǐ diǎn le?

What time is it now?

19 我们要吃饭。

Wǒmen yào chīfàn.

We are going to eat.

21 这个苹果很甜。

Zhège píngguǒ hěn tián.

This apple is very sweet.

23 她是我妹妹。

Tā shì wǒ mèimei.

She is my little sister.

25 我去火车站。

Wǒ qù huǒchēzhàn.

I am going to the train station.

27 他会说汉语。

Tā huì shuō Hànyǔ.

He can speak Chinese.

29 请给我一杯水。

Qǐng gěi wǒ yì bēi shuǐ.

Please give me a glass of water.

31 我学了三年汉语。

Wǒ xué le sān nián Hànyǔ.

I have studied Chinese for three years.

33 你的汉语说得很好！

Nǐ de Hànyǔ shuō de hěn hǎo!

You speak Chinese very well!

35 我听不懂。

Wǒ tīng bù dǒng.

I don't understand.

37 我先走了。

Wǒ xiān zǒu le.

I am leaving first.

10 对不起，我晚了。

Duìbuqǐ, wǒ wǎn le.

Sorry, I am late.

12 谢谢你的帮助。

Xièxie nǐ de bāngzhù.

Thank you for your help.

14 我买了一个苹果。

Wǒ mǎi le yí ge píngguǒ.

I bought an apple.

16 我的手机哪儿去了？

Wǒ de shǒujī nǎr qù le?

Where did my phone go?

18 现在是八点半。

Xiànzài shì bā diǎn bàn.

It is half past eight now.

20 我想看电视。

Wǒ xiǎng kàn diànshì.

I want to watch TV.

22 那个男人是谁？

Nàge nánrén shì shuí?

Who is that man?

24 你去哪儿？

Nǐ qù nǎr?

Where are you going?

26 我们坐飞机去。

Wǒmen zuò fēijī qù.

We will go by plane.

28 我会游泳。

Wǒ huì yóuyóǒng.

I can swim.

30 这本书很好看。

Zhè běn shū hěn hǎokàn.

This book is very good-looking.

32 中文很难，也很有趣。

Zhōngwén hěn nán, yě hěn yǒuqù.

Chinese is hard, but also very interesting.

34 说得太快了，请慢一点。

Shuō de tài kuài le, qǐng màn yìdiǎn.

You speak too fast, please speak slower.

36 再说一遍，好吗？

Zài shuō yí biàn, hǎo ma?

Please say it again, okay?

38 别担心。

Bié dānxīn.

Don't worry.

**39 你吃了没有?**

Nǐ chī le méiyǒu?

Have you eaten?

**41 牛肉面很好吃。**

Niúròu miàn hěn hǎochī.

Beef noodles are delicious.

**43 星期六我们去公园。**

Xīngqīliù wǒmen qù gōngyuán.

We go to the park on Saturday.

**45 他唱歌很好听。**

Tā chànggē hěn hǎotīng.

He sings very nicely.

**47 学习汉语很有意思。**

Xuéxí Hànyǔ hěn yǒu yìsi.

Studying Chinese is very interesting.

**49 外面下雨了。**

Wàimiàn xià yǔ le.

It is raining outside.

**51 冬天很冷。**

Dōngtiān hěn lěng.

Winter is very cold.

**53 我喜欢小狗。**

Wǒ xǐhuān xiǎo gǒu.

I like little dogs.

**55 我爸爸是医生。**

Wǒ bàba shì yīshēng.

My dad is a doctor.

**57 祝你生日快乐!**

Zhù nǐ shēngrì kuàilè!

Happy birthday!

**59 明天见!**

Míngtiān jiàn!

See you tomorrow!

**40 我吃过了。**

Wǒ chī guo le.

I have already eaten.

**42 我想买票。**

Wǒ xiǎng mǎi piào.

I want to buy a ticket.

**44 我们跳舞吧。**

Wǒmen tiàowǔ ba.

Let's dance.

**46 我做了一个梦。**

Wǒ zuò le yí ge mèng.

I had a dream.

**48 这个房间很干净。**

Zhège fángjiān hěn gānjìng.

This room is very clean.

**50 带把伞吧。**

Dài bǎ sǎn ba.

Bring an umbrella.

**52 夏天很热。**

Xiàtiān hěn rè.

Summer is very hot.

**54 猫在椅子上。**

Māo zài yǐzi shàng.

The cat is on the chair.

**56 我妈妈是老师。**

Wǒ māma shì lǎoshī.

My mom is a teacher.

**58 新年快乐!**

Xīnnián kuàilè!

Happy New Year!

**60 很久不见，你更漂亮了。**

Hěn jiǔ bú jiàn, nǐ gèng piàoliang le.

Long time no see — you look prettier!